

Board: 1

Dealer: **West**

Contract: 3NT

Declarer: North

Board: 3

Dealer: **East**

Contract: 3NT

Declarer: East

Board 1

West Deals

None Vul

♠ A 6 2
♥ Q J 10 8 4 3
♦ 9 3
♣ 8 4

♠ Q 10 9

♥ A K 2

♦ K 10 6

♣ K J 9 3

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ 8 7 5 3

♥ 9 6

♦ Q J 8 5

♣ A 7 5

♠ K J 4

♥ 7 5

♦ A 7 4 2

♣ Q 10 6 2

West

2♥

All Pass

North

2NT

East

Pass

South

3NT

3NT by North

You can establish at most 1 winner in ♦s, 2 in ♠s, and 3 in ♣s. Since you must work on both ♠s and ♣s, you don't need to try for anything extra in ♦s.

If West has both black Aces you will go down, but you know that he cannot have two outside Aces with a 6-card ♥ suit headed by the Q J and still open with a weak 2-bid. So East must have at least one of the black Aces.

If you could guess which Ace West holds you could work on that suit first. He would win it, then get his ♥s established, but wouldn't be able to get back in to cash them.

But better than guessing, you should just holdup on the first ♥ trick and win the next one. Then it won't matter which Ace you knock out first because East will not have a ♥ to play in either case.

If you win the first trick and then play ♠s, you will be lucky. West will have to take his ♠A and then establish his ♥s. And when East takes the ♣A he won't have a ♥ to play.

If you win the first trick and then play ♣s, you will be unlucky. East will take his ♣A and play his last ♥. Then when West takes the ♠A he will set you with ♥ tricks.

If you hold up on first trick luck won't come into it. It will no longer matter which black suit you establish first.

You should be sure you and partner are on the same page with this bid. A 2NT overcall over a Weak-2 opener shows the same hand as a 1NT overcall over a 1 of a suit opener. In other words, 15-18 points, and at least 1 (preferably 2), stoppers in their suit.

Partner, who is on the same page, bids 3NT.

North plays 3NT. East leads the ♥9. As expected, East leads his partner's ♥ suit.

Winner List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = 4

You need 5 more winners. This is important to keep in mind.

Board 3

East Deals

E-W Vul

♠ Q 6 3
 ♥ 8 4 2
 ♦ Q 8
 ♣ K Q 10 9 6

♠ J 10 9 5

♥ 7 3

♦ J 10 7 4

♣ 7 4 3

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ A 7 4
 ♥ A K 5
 ♦ A 6 3
 ♣ J 8 5 2

♠ K 8 2

♥ Q J 10 9 6

♦ K 9 5 2

♣ A

West	North	East	South
		1NT	2♥
3♣	Pass	3NT	
All Pass			

3NT by East

First the question of holding up or not. The reason for a hold-up play is to be sure that when North gains the lead he has no ♥s remaining. But in this Deal you can place most of the strength with South so you don't need to hold up. And, in fact, there is a good reason why you shouldn't.

Win the first trick with your ♥K and immediately play a ♣, taken by South's ♣A. He plays the ♥J which you win with your ♥A. North followed suit to the second ♥!

South has 3 ♥ winners in his hand. There is a good chance that he has the ♠K and ♦K as well. So if you play either of those suits, leading toward the Queen, South will jump up with his King and put you down 1. So instead, play a ♣ winner, and when South shows out, play your last ♥! South will smile as he takes his three ♥ winners but then he will frown when he realizes he must lead away from one of his Kings! You, of course, will jump up with dummy's Queen of that suit for your ninth trick.

We learn at bridge that you should lead toward high cards to try to establish them. For example, in this Deal leading toward the ♠Q would establish a winner as long as South held the ♠K. Unfortunately you would be giving up the setting trick as you established the winner.

Always keep in the back of your mind the possibility of an elimination play. In this Deal that meant you needed to refuse the hold-up because you would need the third ♥ to throw South in with.

After the overcall of your partner's opening 1NT you must make a quick decision with this type of hand: Force to game or settle for partscore. Using lebensohl, a suit bid at the 3-level shows a 5-card or longer suit and is game forcing. You go for it by bidding 3♣ (not Stayman) and partner says 3NT.

The contract would be 3NT played by West.

East plays 3NT. South leads the ♥Q. You must make an immediate decision whether to hold up or not.

Winner List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = 4

Of course the ♣ suit will produce 4 winners so you need just one more in ♠s or ♦s.